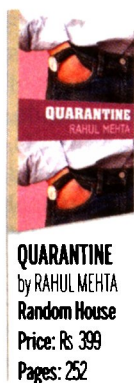


Inverted SEXUALITY

An Indian-American's first collection of short stories on homosexual pain and longing is the worst kind of decadence India can do without at this moment



| By Aatish Taseer |

A few weeks ago, a pamphlet arrived in the mail. Ah, I thought, electronics? A catalogue? The Vishwa Hindu Parishad's political manifesto perhaps? No. But something far worse: three samples from *Quarantine*, a collection of short stories by an Indian-American writer called Rahul Mehta, 36, who teaches English at Alfred University, New York. In an introduction to this publishing gimmick, designed perhaps to stand in for a bound proof, these nine tales of homosexual pain and longing are tragically described as "tender". The stories collected in *Quarantine* are not tender; they are banal and squalid. But most importantly—and the only reason they need be considered at all—they are the manufacture of a creative writing culture that values the politics of identity over talent, voice and originality. And as you make your way through this volume, you can almost hear the commissioning editor's voice: "Oh, yes, let's have that gay Indian-American writer on our list!"

The unfortunate result is *Quarantine*.

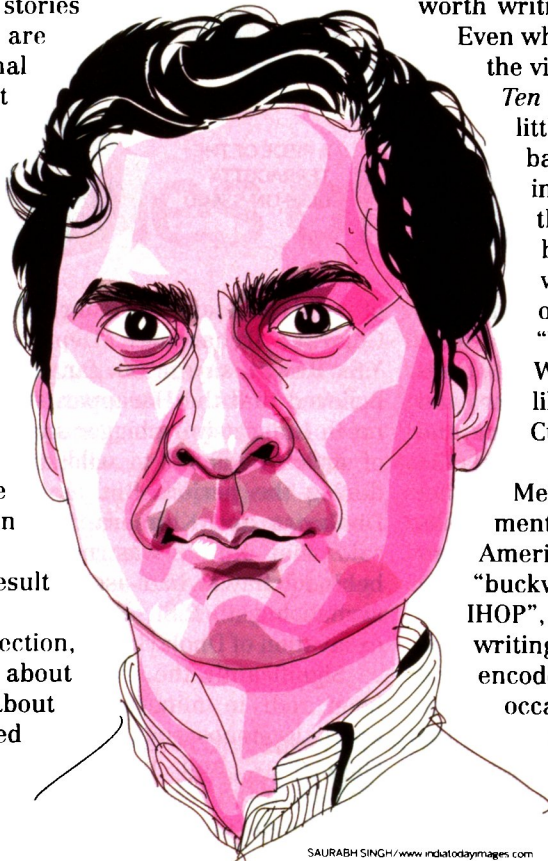
The stories in this collection, though they profess to be about bigger things, are really about manners, about the involved joy and distress a first or second generation immigrant feels as he tries to

master foreign ways. We follow narrator after narrator—usually first person—through a cycle of bad relationships, fraught with well-founded fears of betrayal and deceit, till we come invariably to break-up and break-down. Presumably the same school that gave Mehta his synthetic creative-writing style (always, as a strange matter of fact, identifiable by the use of that disgusting word, "shimmy") also encouraged him to believe that his narrators' concerns—now about whether he knows who recorded the original *I Will Always Love You*, now about whether he will be taken for an American on a visit to Niagara

Falls—were important and interesting, worth writing about. They are not.

Even when his narrator becomes the victim of an infidelity, as in *Ten Thousand Years*, we feel little sympathy for him as he batters his poor boyfriend in a quest to discover what the penis of the man his boyfriend cheats on him with looks like. "I'm the one who got hurt," I said. "You owe me at least this. What did his dick look like? Big? Small? Hooded? Cut? Thin? Thick?"

Though most of the time Mehta sticks to the excitements of suburban and urban American life, complete with "buckwheat pancakes at the IHOP", films at the Angelika, writing courses and other encoded cultural references, occasionally the skeletal remains of his Indian origins surface. And the result, each time, is disastrous.



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